

Psalms 25

Lifting My Soul to God

Unto thee, O Lord, do I lift up my soul

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Unto thee, O LORD, do I lift up my soul.*
- 2 *O my God, I trust in thee: let me not be ashamed, let not mine enemies triumph over me.*
- 3 *Yea, let none that wait on thee be ashamed: let them be ashamed which transgress without cause.*
- 4 *Shew me thy ways, O LORD; teach me thy paths.*
- 5 *Lead me in thy truth, and teach me: for thou art the God of my salvation; on thee do I wait all the day.*
- 6 *Remember, O LORD, thy tender mercies and thy lovingkindnesses; for they have been ever of old.*
- 7 *Remember not the sins of my youth, nor my transgressions: according to thy mercy remember thou me for thy goodness' sake, O LORD.*
- 8 *Good and upright is the LORD: therefore will he teach sinners in the way.*
- 9 *The meek will he guide in judgment: and the meek will he teach his way.*
- 10 *All the paths of the LORD are mercy and truth unto such as keep his covenant and his testimonies.*
- 11 *For thy name's sake, O LORD, pardon mine iniquity; for it is great.*
- 12 *What man is he that feareth the LORD? him shall he teach in the way that he shall choose.*
- 13 *His soul shall dwell at ease; and his seed shall inherit the earth.*
- 14 *The secret of the LORD is with them that fear him; and he will shew them his covenant.*
- 15 *Mine eyes are ever toward the LORD; for he shall pluck my feet out of the net.*
- 16 *Turn thee unto me, and have mercy upon me; for I am desolate and afflicted.*
- 17 *The troubles of my heart are enlarged: O bring thou me out of my distresses.*
- 18 *Look upon mine affliction and my pain; and forgive all my sins.*
- 19 *Consider mine enemies; for they are many; and they hate me with cruel hatred.*
- 20 *O keep my soul, and deliver me: let me not be ashamed; for I put my trust in thee.*
- 21 *Let integrity and uprightness preserve me; for I wait on thee.*
- 22 *Redeem Israel, O God, out of all his troubles.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 25 is an acrostic (each verse beginning with successive Hebrew letters) blending petitions for guidance and forgiveness with confident meditation on God's mercy, truth, and covenant faithfulness toward those who fear Him. David prays as a needy learner—asking to be taught, led, and remembered in mercy rather than according to the sins of his youth—while also affirming, almost as a refrain, that God's ways are mercy and truth to those who keep His covenant. Henry notes how naturally personal petition and general truths about God's character intertwine throughout the psalm.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

Opening trust: soul lifted to God, hope that shame and enemy triumph will not follow, since none who wait on the Lord will be ashamed, while treacherous dealers without cause will be.

Verse 4-7

A prayer for guidance and forgiveness: "Shew me thy ways... lead me in thy truth, and teach me... Remember not the sins of my youth," but remember David according to God's own mercy and goodness, not according to his failures.

Verse 8-10

Meditation on God's character: good and upright, teaching sinners in the way, guiding the meek in judgment, and revealing that "all the paths of the Lord are mercy and truth" to those who keep His covenant and testimonies.

Verse 11-14

For God’s name’s sake, a request for pardon of “great” sin, paired with confidence that the one who fears the Lord will be taught the way to choose, will dwell at ease, and whose seed will inherit the earth—since “the secret of the Lord is with them that fear him.”

Verse 15-18

Eyes continually toward the Lord for deliverance from a net; petitions to turn and have mercy, since David is desolate and afflicted; a plea to look upon affliction and pain and to forgive all his sins.

Verse 19-22

A closing set of petitions: consider the enemies, deliver from their many and cruel hatred, preserve integrity and uprightness as a guard, and let not those who wait on God be ashamed. The final verse widens from personal plea to national concern: “Redeem Israel, O God, out of all his troubles.”

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine dependence on God combines humble requests for guidance and forgiveness with confident meditation on His covenant character—mercy and truth toward all who fear and wait on Him.

Application for life today.

Practice the psalm’s opening posture—literally lifting your soul in prayer—as a daily reset rather than only a crisis response. Bring both categories of request modeled here: ask God to teach and guide you in specific decisions, and ask Him to deal with old sins according to His mercy rather than your record. And let your personal petitions, like David’s, eventually widen outward to prayer for your community or nation’s troubles.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What decision right now needs the guidance prayer of verses 4–5 (“shew me thy ways... teach me”)?

2. Is there a “sin of your youth” or old failure you need to ask God to remember according to His mercy rather than your record?

3. How could your personal prayers this week expand, as David’s do in verse 22, to include your wider community?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).